The Reactionary Nature of Popular Answers to the Two Week Phase

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Preface

In the title and throughout this essay, I use the word “reactionary”. This term is typically used in politics and philosophy to refer to right-wing ideologies and their tendency to, well, react—however, here I am applying it to Minecraft Theory (MT). How I define “reactionary" within the domain of MT is different; I define it as follows: *describing non-systematic surface level analyses of Minecraft that suggest that the problems encountered in Minecraft today are a result of changes to the game and its community, and proposing a return to a previous state before prior to the changes as a solution to these problems*. This term should be considered separate but analogous to the common real-world definition. This essay is not here to identify the politics of the creators of these videos or people with similar ideas, nor is it here to suggest that the ideas posited by these creators are wholly reactionary or even wholly incorrect. What I am here to do though is to share a perspective on these videos that has plagued me for quite some time. And in turn, I hope to provide a helpful guide on what one should avoid when writing MT.

Over the years, as all things do, the Minecraft game and its community have changed. What used to be a lesser-known title has become one of the best-selling games worldwide. With this has come a very active player base, one which grows a culture of its own, and a studio that wants to keep that player base happy. This change has led to many reactions, and more recently, criticisms primarily of how the game is played today have developed. My first impressions of the game came around 2015 when I played Minecraft for the first time on version 1.8. I remember how much I enjoyed it. It was a new world in which my creativity could run wild. I look back at it very fondly; a time before I fell into the dreaded loop of the “Two Week Minecraft Phase”. However, I recognize that those memories are varnished with childhood nostalgia. I understand

that I will not be able to go back to that time, and thus, I choose to look forward to a new Minecraft experience—one that adapts to the context of today, using Minecraft Theory. The same cannot be said for many of the popular solutions proposed online around the time the Two Week Minecraft Phase was being popularized. Mostly on YouTube, these videos have garnered a lot of popularity but not much critique despite the fact that they don't adhere much to our 'modern' understanding of these topics and are actively reductive in their analysis. This popular view can be illustrated by the videos that will be analyzed here, which are: SirGiovanni's video, "How To Make The 2 Week Minecraft Phase Last Forever", with over 100,000 views and over 500 comments and niko's video, "The 2 Week Minecraft Phase Explained", with over two million views and over five thousand comments. The early ideas presented in these videos should be considered reactionary within the realm of Minecraft Theory.

Reactionary ideas would not develop in a world without problems. Without conflict there is nothing to react to. What these popular videos identify as the sources of these problems shows us how limited their frameworks are. They present a world in which change spontaneously appears and starts to cause problems—niko's video highlights this quite nicely. His general analysis advocates playing the game "without subscribing to whatever the current update or meta is for the game right now" (2024, 6:30). While there's nothing wrong with viewing certain ways of playing the game as detrimental, niko doesn't identify this, he is specifically talking about what is "new". Without explaining what the problem with the new update or meta is; niko focuses on the appearance of a problem in the symbol of change without getting to the underlying problem with the change. Another problem he addresses is that content creators don't play the game how it is "meant to be played" (niko, 2024). In his argument, he suggests that content creators who seek popularity and profit are fostering a community in which Minecraft is played in the wrong way, and therefore playing the way a YouTuber plays is what is hurting *your* Minecraft experience; rather than any sort of structure that incentivizes this behavior.

Slightly different in presentation, SirGiovanni posits a functionally identical analysis. SirGiovanni's argument is different in that it focuses more on what has been *"*lost" than what has been gained (not in a positive way) from change. A prime example of this is how he believes creativity has been "lost" within the Minecraft community (2024, 5:13). This analysis is surface level. It doesn't present any cause-and-effect behind it, and as a result of this, he does not give a

remedy beyond, “be more creative”. Earlier in the video, he discusses a similar sense of loss, saying that “we’ve gotten away from expanding worlds and playing on worlds long term” (SirGiovanni, 2024, 3:12). Similarly to the point on creativity, the creator characterizes a change as bad without making a case for it. SirGiovanni’s way of thinking exemplifies the non-systematic element of reactionary MT. His line of argumentation is functionally analogous to niko’s because of how it implies that the past was better without identifying any underlying problems—but simply saying that it is something to be returned to. The creators identify an issue, but they fail to show how the issue arises. Why do you think that it is only now that YouTube affects how the game is played? Why is there a loss in creativity now? These are questions that a reactionary analysis of Minecraft cannot answer.

So, what is the aforementioned past that they advocate we should return to? Rather than actually looking into the past, they’re referring to what *they* prescribe as the correct way of playing Minecraft. They don’t bring up how Minecraft was designed nor how it was intended to be played according to the developers, but they declare how Minecraft is *meant* to be played and how it *should* be played. What they use as evidence is an appeal to intention, constituting an *intentional fallacy* (see: Britannica, 2016). In niko’s video, he provides a seemingly relatable anecdote to his viewers; saying, “we all have that one friend who speedruns the game to the point to where he has 64 Diamond Blocks and 43 Elytras…Minecraft was not meant to be played like that; It was meant to be played at a much slower pace” (2024, 3:37). He presents a problem which, as he says, “we all have”, and then he juxtaposes it with what he interprets as the “correct” way of playing the game. This creates a binary understanding of how Minecraft is played, simplifying it to a point unrecognizable from reality. Also, small side tangent, this framing, particularly in using the word “speedrun”, serves to devalue speedrunners’ work and enjoyment of the game. People who speedrun are not “enjoying the game in the wrong way” because there is no *wrong* way to enjoy a game. Speaking from personal experience, game designers try to encourage certain behavior or feeling in their design, however this does not mean that players will actually adhere to the designers’ intention, nor does it mean that the designers’ intention is the *most fun* way to play a game—at least not for everyone. A similarly simplified idea is presented by SirGiovanni, claiming that “in the newer versions we just get so caught up in doing all the extracurricular things… that we kind of forget the core reason why we play this

game and why this game was made in the first place" (SirGiovanni, 2024, 2:21). Once again, we see an appeal to intention, as well as a somewhat obscured appeal to nature in implying the existence of a core reason for playing the game that we *all* have (see: Britannica, 2012). Both niko and SirGiovanni go on to basically say that building and what they call "creativity" are the intended ways of playing Minecraft (niko, 2024; SirGiovanni, 2024). We see them develop this argument with something generally considered positive, which is creativity, and saying that that is what Minecraft is about. These ideas are reactionary in that they revert back to a simplistic model of Minecraft in order to justify their view of intention and nature being the superior way of playing the game. The problem with these reactionary ideas is that they present a "correct" way of playing Minecraft, which is a highly black and white view and directly antithetical to the common understanding within the contemporary Minecraft Theory community.

Now that we understand their arguments, we can look at what they have to back it up, which is… *nothing*. As alluded to previously, neither of the videos here actually cite *anything*. Their entire understanding and basis of their thesis is anecdotal evidence that they presume *you*, the viewer, have experienced too. Not even an example to point to, it's purely based on vibes and rationalizing themselves into a world view. They don't even pretend to understand Maslow's hierarchy of needs! This is fine, of course, within the context of a YouTube video; people don't go in expecting a source of authority. They weren't made in the context of MT—it is only now that the subject is taken a bit more seriously within a small, albeit passionate niche. Even a lot of MT YouTubers don't cite their sources (though, references to other videos may be made). It becomes a problem once they *do* start presenting themselves as a source of authority without qualifying that their ideas are purely their own without any evidence beyond anecdote. All of this is to make a very obvious point; these videos should not be taken seriously within the realm of MT. Other than understanding the development of MT, they are redundant and reductive in understanding Minecraft as it is. How they present their argument is not the direction the MT community should go in; something that MT YouTube especially should keep in mind. If we want to be taken seriously, we first need to take ourselves seriously and in doing that recognize when and when not to lend credit to something.

Something in particular that we should not take seriously is when these videos use emotion over evidence. SirGiovanni and niko employ the use of nostalgia to resonate with their

viewers. This goes hand in hand with the ideas presented that Minecraft just used to be better, referring to the game and the community. An example we see throughout both niko and SirGiovanni's videos is the use of older versions as background visuals (niko, 2024; SirGiovanni, 2024). The use of these visuals serves as a trigger of childhood nostalgia within the viewer. This then forms the association between their argument, their prescription, and that feeling. The assumption that, in the cloud of nostalgia, they were playing the game in the "correct way" in the past, according to SirGiovanni and niko's assessment. Nostalgia isn't a concept that they are trying to hide from the viewer, of course, both of them freely bring up how nostalgia plays a role in the desire to play Minecraft (niko, 2024; SirGiovanni, 2024). However, they don't go further beyond this, they don't investigate whether this emotion is clouding their judgement. This is a reactionary position—viewing the past through an idealized lens as a source of authority on the matters of today. This doesn't mean that nostalgia should never be discussed within MT circles, but nostalgia should never be used in the place of real evidence.

SirGiovanni, niko and anyone else positing similar ideas are not acting in malice or trying to mislead. These videos came out before the IMS, before the currency debate, and before anything else we would consider Minecraft Theory, but they show a clear desire to understand the game that they love. When analyzing a piece of media, it is easy to get caught up in the sentimentality of things. Presenting Minecraft as a misunderstood masterpiece is a romantic idea, an infantilizing one. But that ideal can lead to reactionary tendencies. These reactionary tendencies then lead to actually misunderstanding Minecraft on a fundamental level. I wouldn't even say that all the ideas that they present are wrong per se, I agree that playing Minecraft at a slower pace will lead to more enjoyment, I agree that social media has played a part in making the modern Minecraft experience worse, and I agree that creativity is important. However, the difference is that I see change as an avenue for solutions rather than a malicious force that should be avoided at all costs. Minecraft Theory should be considered a science, and science is based on evidence, proper analysis, and the scientific method. In that way, science and reactionary thought are inherently contradictory. If we, as Minecraft Theorists and as members of the IMS, want to foster a community that is healthy, taken seriously, and respects evidence and the scientific method, it is necessary that we understand that the reactionary approach to Minecraft analysis is actively detrimental and counter-productive toward our goals as a community.

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